

Carne Asada Picada

Garlic-forward marinade · diced shoulder clod · griddle chop-and-sear · lime at the taco

PORTION	THAW = MARINATE	DICE	FREEZER
450 g bags	overnight, fridge	$\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ " cross-grain	3+ months

KEY TARGETS

it's beef — sear hard, pull at medium, don't cook it through

Griddle surface (IR)	450–500°F	Internal pull temp	130–140°F
Char coverage	15–20%	Final texture	crusty edge, tender
Dice	$\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ ", cross-grain	Marinade	coats, not watery

MARINADE FORMULA

% of beef wt · per full ~24 lb (11 kg) clod — weigh yours, multiply

Beef shoulder clod diced $\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ ", across grain	100%	11 kg
Garlic peeled cloves, to blend — the lead	3.5%	385 g
White onion rough chunks, to blend	4%	440 g
Maggi seasoning Jugo — umami backbone	2%	220 g
Neutral or olive oil	3%	330 g
Cumin, ground warm background	0.5%	55 g
Mexican oregano	0.4%	44 g
Black pepper	0.4%	44 g
Salt Diamond Crystal, by wt	1.3%	143 g

No acid in the bag — on purpose. Over this bulk **season** → **freeze** → **thaw** cycle, lime would sit on the beef for the whole slow thaw and bully the meat flavor (and soften lean beef). Instead it's seasoned **beef-forward** — cumin, garlic, Maggi, and onion penetrate — and you bring the brightness with **fresh lime + salsa at the taco**, where it actually pops. **No acid also means the thaw is worry-free:** thaw fully in the fridge, **pat dry, sear ripping hot. Dice across the grain and pull at medium** — it's beef, not the pollo, so don't cook it through. **No heat in the bag** either — salsas + chiles at the table. **Salt by weight:** Diamond Crystal at 1.3%; Morton = 60% of that, table = 50%.

Make Ahead & Cook

PREP & FREEZE

build the bags ahead — the marinade works through the freeze + thaw

- 1 **Dice:** trim the shoulder clod and cut $\frac{3}{8}$ – $\frac{1}{2}$ " (1–1.5 cm) **cubes across the grain** — uniform for even searing, cross-grain for tenderness.
- 2 **Blend:** everything except the beef into a blender — blend smooth (a splash of water to get it moving if needed). No grating; it scales clean and coats evenly for bulk.
- 3 **Combine:** toss the diced beef in the blended marinade until every piece is coated — a large tub / bus tub for a full clod.
- 4 **Portion + freeze:** into quart bags (450 g each), press flat, remove air, label with the date, freeze **right away** — **no separate marinate step**. The meat marinates as it freezes and thaws.

COOK FROM FROZEN

ripping-hot griddle — sear, don't steam

- 5 **Thaw:** fridge **overnight** — it seasons as it thaws, and with **no acid there's no mush risk**, so a full thaw is fine. **Pat dry** going in for a clean sear.
- 6 **Griddle:** cast iron / flat-top ripping hot (**IR 450–500°F**), light oil. **Single layer, don't crowd** — pat surfaces dry going in. Hard sear.
- 7 **Chop-and-sear:** add fresh sliced white onion alongside if you like; chop with two spatulas, let it sit **30–60 sec**, toss for crispy edges.
- 8 **Finish:** pull at **medium, 130–140°F**. **This is where the lime lives** — squeeze fresh lime over, then cilantro, onion, salsas / chiles. Double-stacked tortillas, flaky salt. Brightness *and* heat both come on at the table.

TROUBLESHOOTING

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Tough / chewy	Cut with the grain, or overcooked	Dice across the grain; pull at 130–140°F
No char	Griddle too cool or crowded	Single layer; recover to 450–500°F
Dull, no brightness	No acid in the bag (by design)	Fresh lime + salsa at the table — that's the brightness
Gray, not seared	Wet surface or crowded pan	Pat dry going in; smaller batches; hotter pan
Bland	Under-salted	Salt to 1.3% by weight; thaw fully so it penetrates